—involving ‘directional alignment and geometrical and astronomical coordinates’,[17] as well as the dictates of *Vastu Shastra*. They exemplified the Nagara style—tall shikhara towers and other spirals atop inner sanctums evoke the Himalayan abode of the gods. People from all walks of life visited them not just to worship but to also partake in cultural events and to enjoy the bustling life of their capital. ‘In the halls of temples, religious texts were recited, and dance and music was performed,’ writes Desai. ‘The Chandella dramatists composed plays, both mythical and farcical, to be staged during temple festivals.’

Across India, the later centuries of the first millennium CE were an age of new popular-mystical faiths and sects that were distinct from Brahminism. Their roots often lay in the folk beliefs, animistic cults and rituals of peoples either outside or at the margins of the Vedic fold (which may have included the subaltern forebears of the Chandela kings). Mostly disinterested in the Vedic corpus and its sacrificial rituals, these sects emphasized devotion to a personal god, worshipped idols and a vast range of non-Vedic deities, and drew upon stories from texts known as Puranas and *Agamas*. As these folk beliefs coalesced, the adherents clustered into three broad sects—Shaiva, Vaishnava, Shakta-Tantra—and even gained upper-class disciples and patrons who were perhaps breaking away from Buddhism or Vedic Brahminism.

This emerging religiosity, often called Puranic Hinduism, was flexible enough to absorb multiple local deities as forms (or avatars) of their primary gods. While each sect imparted an identity to its members, their actual beliefs and practices displayed much fusion and plurality. The later Chandelas, for instance, subscribed to a faith that fused worship of Shiva with Tantric ideas. These Puranic sects also variously absorbed Vedantic Brahminism—its rituals, texts, caste rules, Advaita thought, etc.—to give rise to what scholars would later call Hinduism. It was this Hinduism, plus some Jainism, that made up the religious landscape of Khajuraho.[18] There was virtually no Buddhism, which by now had receded mostly to eastern India.

The Chandelas suffered the vicissitudes of war often enough, whether against the Chedis of Jabalpur, the Chalukyas of Gujarat or the Rajput king Prithviraj Chauhan of Ajmer. In 1022, the Chandelas successfully rebuffed